work of security services and governments (a fact that would bring us much hostility when it came to altering the documents we leaked); we simply felt it was for history to judge what was in the ‘public interest’ and what was not. We would use our best editorial judgement, but it was not for us to do as most media organisations do, and act as censors on behalf of governments and commercial interests. We would reveal what we judged should never have been made covert: others would take it further. And almost always our efforts would lead us into a lion’s den of self-interest.

Talking about the lion’s roar? Look at the case of Switzerland’s Bank Julius Baer, who – even in times of banking crisis – were subject to allegations of malfeasance thanks to our having taken custody of important revelations about them in January 2008. Julius Baer is the largest Swiss bank and it has trusts in the Cayman Islands. We were given evidence that those trusts were used for asset-hiding and tax minimisation, arguably tax avoidance, and it seemed entirely in the public interest that we revealed what these people were doing and to what extent they were doing it. Right on publication, we received legal notice from a lawyer who wouldn’t even reveal who his client was, but the potential litigant was Julius Baer. The legal firm, Ludley & Sanger, are a Hollywood outfit representing the likes of Celine Dion and Arnold Schwarzenegger, who specialise in keeping things out of print. They’re very aggressive and they came on hard. They made various threats and were going on about banking law and secrecy law in the Cayman Islands and in Switzerland, proper baloney, but our own lawyer told us these people were too powerful to mess with, too connected, too rich, that they would stop at nothing and the whole thing was too murky. I said we would certainly go ahead and publish and stand by the publication: I had established certain principles against censorship and would not fold. We had made promises that if sources gave us good material we would publish it, and we were uncensorable: that’s what our technology dictated, and that’s what our ethic dictated, too, as a matter of fact. It didn’t mean, ‘We are uncensorable, except in cases where a very rich person appears to scare us off.’ I knew that, tactically, this might be a very difficult (and potentially ruinous) first fight, but we had established a principle and that was that.

Like everything else, it was a giant lesson delivered in real time. We were being brutally squeezed by a relentless patronage network, in this case two branches of that network, Julius Baer and the American lawyers, the former